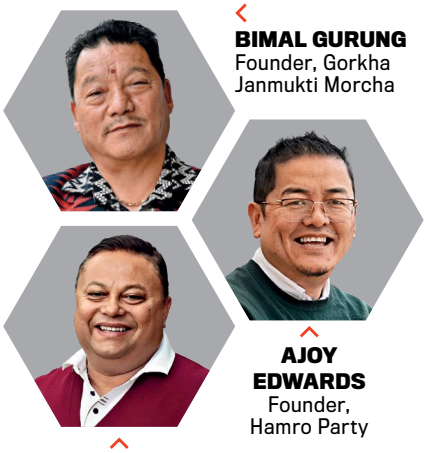
rant and founder of the Hamro Party (HP). The trio may not be contesting the election themselves but, as power brokers, their support is being seen as crucial for the candidates in the fray. At stake is not just one Lok Sabha seat, but also Gurung, Edwards and Thapa's hold on public opinion.

The total population of Darjeeling district according to the 2011 census (Kalimpong was then a part of Darjeeling) was 1.85 million. Nepali-speaking Gorkhas, the community which has for decades been demanding separation from West Bengal, reportedly comprised about 46 per cent of the population. The movement for Gorkhaland saw the formation of the Darjeeling Gorkha Hill Council (DGHC) in 1988, a semi-autonomous council for the administration of Darjeeling, and in 2012, the semi-autonomous Gorkhaland Territorial Administration (GTA). Gurung, who had stepped out of the shadow of Subhash Ghising—the face of the Gorkhaland movement in the 1980s and '90s—to form his own Gorkha Janmukti Morcha (GJM) in 2007, became the first chief of the GTA in 2012. However, owing to the filing of multiple criminal cases against him, following violent protests against the ruling Trinamool Congress in West Bengal, Gurung was forced to flee Darjeeling in 2017. When he returned in 2020, it was by pledging loyalty to Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee. In conversation with INDIA TODAY, Gurung claims he was forced to support Banerjee in 2020, and later in the 2021 assembly election in West Bengal, to facilitate his own, and his supporters', return to the hills. For the coming election, he has thrown in his lot with the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), which he had also supported in the 2019 Lok Sabha polls. For BJP candidate and sitting MP from Darjeeling Raju Bista, however, being nominated itself is an achievement of sorts—this is the first time that the BJP, which has won the seat for the past three general elections, has repeated a candidate. Bista had won the seat in 2019 by a record margin of more than 400,000 votes. While the MP voices confidence of retaining the seat, Gurung says, "I was not present here in 2019 and had released an audio clip seeking support for Raju Bista. He won by a margin of more than four lakh. Now, I am working at ground zero, and you will see the difference".

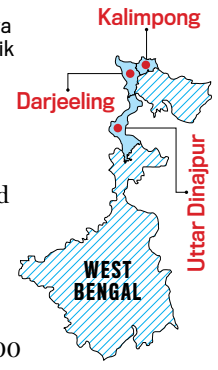
THE POWER BROKERS



BIMAL GURUNG
Founder, Gorkha Janmukti Morcha

AJOY EDWARDS
Founder, Hamro Party

ANIT THAPA
Founder, Bharatiya Gorkha Prajatantrik Morcha



What may make Gurung's work difficult is that, unlike in its 2019 election *Sankalp Patra,* which had talked about a 'permanent political solution' for the hills, the BJP makes no mention of the Gorkhaland issue in its 2024 manifesto. The former GTA chief may also not have accounted for the changed realities in Darjeeling. During his absence, his former aide Thapa formed the Bharatiya Gorkha Prajatantrik Morcha (BGPM) and joined hands with the TMC. According to Thapa, CM Mamata Banerjee is the only mainstream political leader who genuinely loves the Gorkhas (an idea Gurung strongly opposes). The BGPM currently runs the GTA, the Darjeeling municipality and is the largest party in the two-tier panchayat system in the hill area, but Thapa has yet to achieve the clout that Gurung once enjoyed among the Gorkhas. The party also seems doubtful about the voters' response to the TMC. The BGPM is supporting Gopal Lama, a former bureaucrat, who is officially a TMC candidate. However, on ground, he is being projected as a BGPM candidate seeking votes on the TMC symbol. Posters seeking votes for Lama do not feature Mamata Banerjee, unlike those of TMC candidates in most other seats. Thapa denies the TMC is a liability for the party. "Didi [as Banerjee is popularly addressed] has allowed us to keep the autonomy in the hills," he says.

Meanwhile, for Edwards, who is supporting Congress candidate Munish Tamang, the battle is more idealistic. Edwards shot to fame after his party won 18 of the 32 seats in the Darjeeling municipal polls in February 2022 months after its formation. Nine months later, however, he lost the municipality as many of his councillors defected to the BGPM. HP also won eight seats in the 45-strong GTA in 2022, though it currently holds only six, again owing to defections. According to Edwards, his decision to support the Congress was born of his desire to see a Gorkha candidate at the 'high table'. "We need a strong Gorkha voice nationally," he says.

Sources in the Darjeeling administration say no one leader enjoys supreme authority in Darjeeling currently. "Do not expect a walkover for the BJP this time," says a police source. "The brute support for Raju [Bista] came in 2019 right after the 2017 agitation [of the GJM], during which a strong anti-TMC sentiment developed in the hills. That will not be repeated this time." The counting of votes on June 4 will not only decide the fate of the contesting candidates in Darjeeling but also the local forces standing behind them. ■